

From Policy to Practice: The Human Side of SRE

Unpacking the human side of Site Reliability Engineering to boost resilience and transparency in technology organisations

A Blameless Policy is Easy; A Blameless Incident is the True Test

The Reality Check

Most organisations have a documented 'blameless' policy. It's written into handbooks, posted on walls, and referenced in onboarding sessions. But here's the uncomfortable truth: having the policy is easy. **Living it during an actual incident is where the real challenge lies.**

The gap between policy and practice is what transforms a theoretical commitment to blamelessness into genuine psychological safety—and that's what we'll explore today.

95%

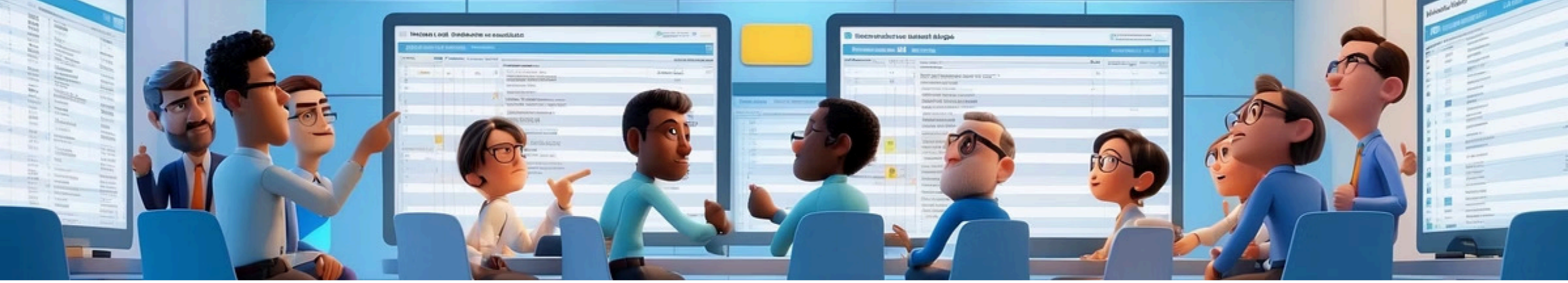
Have Policies

Organisations with documented blameless policies

42%

Feel Safe

Engineers who feel truly safe admitting mistakes



The Post-Mortem Blame Game

The Atmosphere

The air is thick with unsaid accusations. The search for a root cause feels uncomfortably like a search for a scapegoat. Silence becomes strategic.

The Defence Mechanisms

Engineers become guarded, focusing on deflecting blame rather than uncovering systemic flaws. Contributions are measured, carefully worded to avoid implication.

The Consequence

The same incidents happen again because the true, underlying process issues are never addressed. The cycle of firefighting continues unabated.

The "Blameless" Paradox

The Policy

> "We learn from our mistakes without blame, fostering an environment of trust and continuous improvement."

The Reality

- "Who pushed the last change?"
- "Why wasn't this caught in testing?"
- "Why didn't you follow the runbook?"

This paradox creates a culture of anxiety that discourages transparency and punishes the very people you need to learn from. The policy on the wall and the feeling in the room exist in two different worlds.



Creating Psychological Safety

Psychological safety is the shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking—admitting mistakes, asking questions, and challenging the status quo without fear of humiliation or punishment.

01

Recognition

Acknowledge that blamelessness is the goal, but psychological safety is the essential path to get there

02

Engineering Safety

Build tangible systems—not just good intentions—that make safety the default, not the exception

03

Consistent Practice

Demonstrate safety during the most stressful moments when engineers are watching your actions most closely

Our Framework: Three Pillars of Blameless Practice

Drawing from our experience at a global FinTech organisation where reliability is paramount, we developed a practical, human-centric framework built on three foundational pillars.



Pillar 1

Rotating On-Call Role

A structured system to distribute operational load and transform on-call into a guided learning opportunity



Pillar 2

Structured Reviews

Standardised, engineer-led incident reviews focused on systemic flaws, guided by clear policy



Pillar 3

Onboarding for Resilience

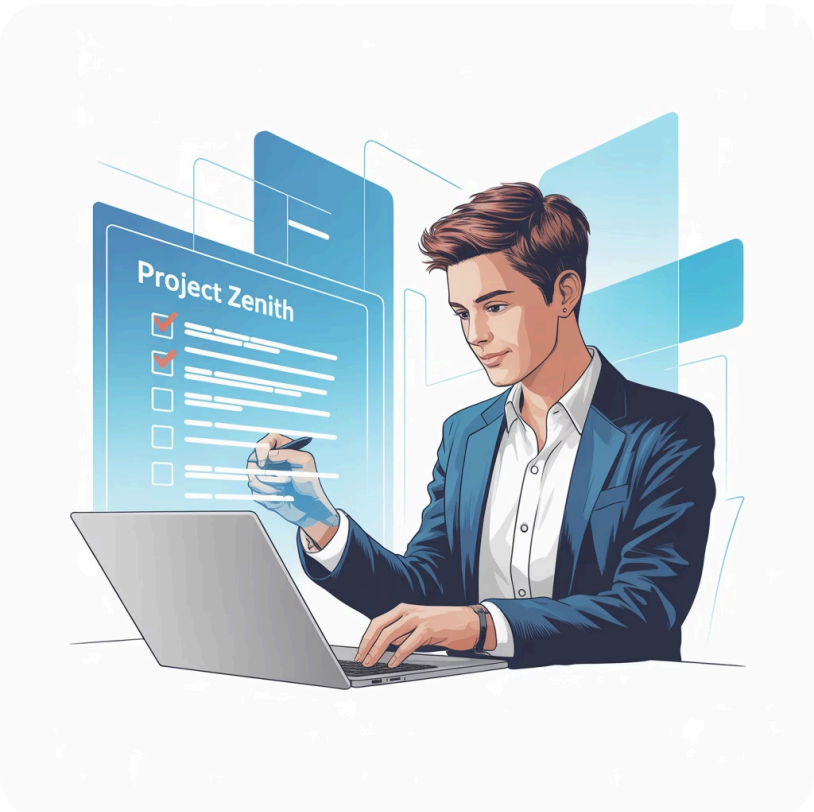
A clear path for new engineers to gain confidence through documentation and mentorship

Pillar 1: The Rotating "Triage Ninja" Role

Demystifies on-call duty

Prevents knowledge silos

Provides safe, hands-on experience



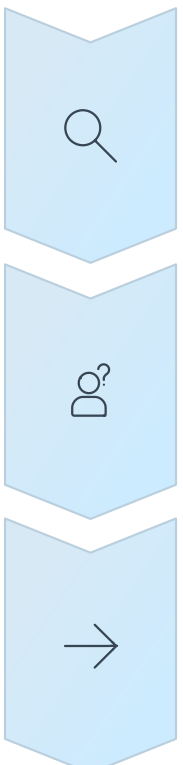
The Concept

A weekly rotating on-call responsibility serving as the **single point of contact** for triaging any incident. The "Triage Ninja" (TN) isn't expected to know everything or fix everything alone—that's the key to making it a safe learning experience.

Empowerment Through Documentation

The "Triage Ninja 101" guide provides a comprehensive, step-by-step checklist covering everything from initial setup in GoAlert to finding RCAs and preparing the weekly summary report for handover.

Pillar 2: The Anatomy of a Blameless Review



Focus on 'What,' Not 'Who'

Our Incident Response Policy explicitly frames reviews as opportunities to improve systems, not to identify culprits. We do not blame any person or team—this is stated clearly and reinforced consistently.

Mandatory "5 Whys" Analysis

Our RCA template requires a structured "5 Whys" approach, forcing the conversation past superficial causes to uncover deeper process or system flaws that enabled the incident.

Systemic Action Items

The final sections focus on "Action needed to reduce detection time" and "How can we mitigate this in the future?", ensuring outcomes are forward-looking fixes, not backward-looking blame.



The Incident Lifecycle in Action

Alert & Acknowledge

An alert fires in GoAlert. The TN acknowledges it within 10 minutes to halt escalations and initiate investigation.

Investigate & Document

The TN follows standard operating procedures, investigating with OpenSearch and Grafana, and records all findings on a JIRA ticket.

Escalate or Mitigate

The TN either mitigates the incident using a runbook or escalates to the Module Incident Coordinator (MIC) if deeper expertise is needed—escalation is always encouraged.

Review & Learn

The incident and RCA are discussed at the weekly review. A summary is prepared for handover to the next TN, ensuring continuous knowledge transfer.

Story: The "Time Travelling Customer"

The Incident

A customer books a flight from New York to New Delhi departing on 1st October. But the e-ticket screen in our app displays 2nd October whilst the PDF shows the correct date. The customer is understandably confused and frustrated—their flight appears to be "time travelling."

The Technical Finding

The backend was sending departure dates as epoch timestamps. The client rendered the epoch in the user's local timezone, causing the date to shift forward by a day for customers in earlier timezones.

The 'Blameful' Gut Reaction

"Which developer used epoch for dates? That's a basic mistake! Why didn't QA's test plan cover different timezones?"



Story: The Blameless Outcome

Asking "Why?"

The "5 Whys" revealed this was a **legacy design choice** from when the target audience was only in India. The global implications were "not thought through" as the product scaled internationally.

Shifting Focus

The analysis shifted from individual blame to examining the original design decision and the processes that allowed it to persist as the product expanded globally.

Systemic Fixes

We deprecated sending epoch for dates across all APIs. Crucially, we added **"timezone considerations"** to both the development analysis checklist and the QA test case creation framework—fixing the system, not just the symptom.

By asking "why" instead of "who," we transformed a potential blame session into a catalyst for permanent process improvement that prevents similar issues across the entire platform.

The Rewards: A Healthier, Faster Team



Reduced Stress & Improved Focus

Engineers spend their energy solving problems, not defending their actions. This clarity leads to faster, more effective incident response and better decision-making under pressure.



Higher Team Velocity

With less time spent on repeat incidents and stressful reviews, teams have significantly more capacity for feature development and proactive system improvements.



Knowledge Democratisation

The Triage Ninja role and open reviews break down knowledge silos, making the entire team more capable and resilient—not just a handful of "heroes."



The Long-Term Impact

From Fire-Fighting to Innovation

Improved Code Quality

When engineers aren't afraid to discuss potential weaknesses, they write better, more defensive code and conduct more thorough peer reviews. Collaboration replaces concealment.

Elimination of Dead Weight

The cycle of recurring incidents, blame-filled meetings, and hero-based firefighting is replaced by a system of continuous improvement and shared ownership.

Meeting Our Imperative

This cultural framework enables us to consistently meet a **99.95% SLA** on business-critical products in a highly regulated FinTech environment—where reliability isn't optional.

Your Blueprint for Change

01

Engineer Your Process for Safety

Implement a rotating on-call role with comprehensive documentation (your version of "Triage Ninja 101") to transform on-call from a source of anxiety into a guided learning experience.

02

Standardise Your Incident Review

Create a simple, repeatable RCA template that mandates the "5 Whys" analysis to force a focus on systemic failures, not individual culpability.

03

Lead by Example

During incidents, managers and senior leaders must consistently model curiosity over judgement, asking "How can we improve the system?" instead of "Whose fault was this?"

Questions & Discussion

We'd be happy to answer your questions and discuss how you can adapt these principles to your organisation's specific context and challenges.